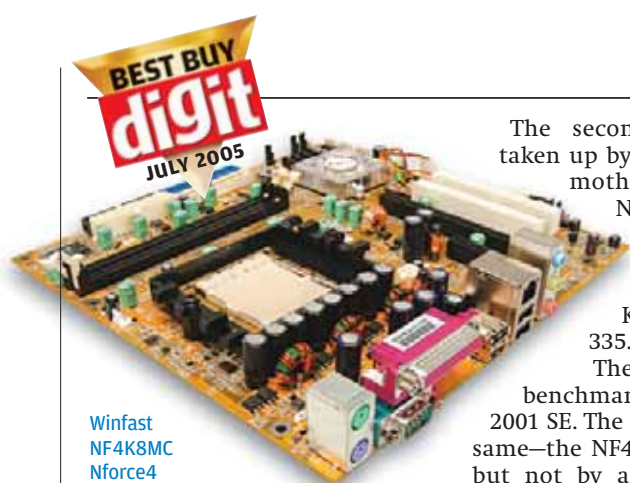




Winfast
NF4K8MC
nForce4

board logged a whopping 185 fps at the lowest settings and 145.2 at 800 x 600.

The second-highest scores were by a WinFast board again, the NF4K8AB at 170.2 and 135.2 respectively. To compare these scores to those of boards with onboard graphics is not entirely correct. These scores are slightly deceiving as these boards were tested with an external graphics card which bumped up the scores.

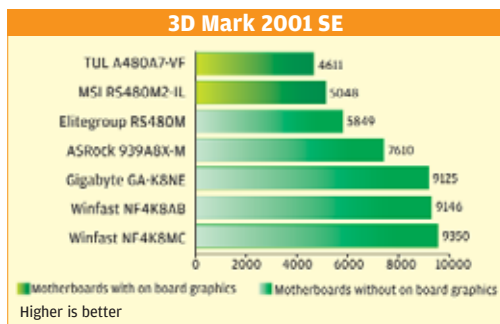
The Gigabyte GA-K8NE came in second and logged 157.4 and 138.8 respectively, and hence marginally beat the NF4K8AB at the more demanding resolution settings. The rear was brought up by the nForce3-based Asus K8N. This board logged a measly 44 and 35.6 in our tests, and was indeed the worst performer in our tests despite having a 6200 (AGP 8X) to help it out! You must, however, note that even though it scored the lowest in our tests, it still gave a more-than-playable frame rate, and hence must not be discounted entirely.

All boards did a bit too well in our Quake 3 Arena test. The WinFast NF4K8MC raced ahead with a score of 400 and 296.6 for the same resolutions as above. The gaming performance of the nForce4-based motherboards could also be high due to our using an nVidia-based motherboard with an nVidia-based graphics card.

The second position was taken up by another WinFast motherboard, the NF4K8AB. It scored 375.6 and 235.5, and easily beat the Gigabyte GA-K8NE, which scored 335.2 and 209.4.

The final graphics benchmark was 3DMark 2001 SE. The story here was the same—the NF4K8MC came first, but not by a long margin. It scored 9350 where the NF4K8AB scored a close 9146 and came in second, just edging out the Gigabyte GA-K8NE, which scored 9125. This was pretty much a tie, as this difference in scores is really insignificant.

The ASRock did a commendable job and logged 7610 despite being an AGP board. Other AGP boards crashed out: 5849 for the ATi RS480-based Elite Group RS480 M, while the Asus K8N was our worst performer once again, scoring just 4939 3DMarks.



The board, while not being too high on performance, was a mark above the others in terms of features, as it had five PCI slots and eight-channel onboard audio.

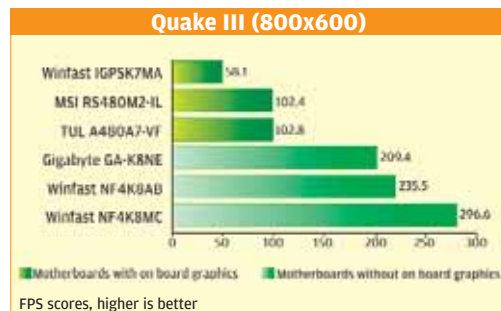
Motherboards With Onboard Graphics

Amongst the motherboards with onboard graphics, the best scorer was the MSI RS480M2-IL. It logged 62.7 and 45.8 for Serious Sam at 640 x 480 and 800 x 600 respectively.

The second here, and by a long way, was the TUL A480A7-VF. It logged 53 and 38.6 respectively. The worst performer was the Asus K8SMX on the SiS chipset, which

logged a very unplayable 26 fps at the lowest graphics settings.

The story was replicated in Quake 3, the RS480M2-IL beating all the others comfortably.



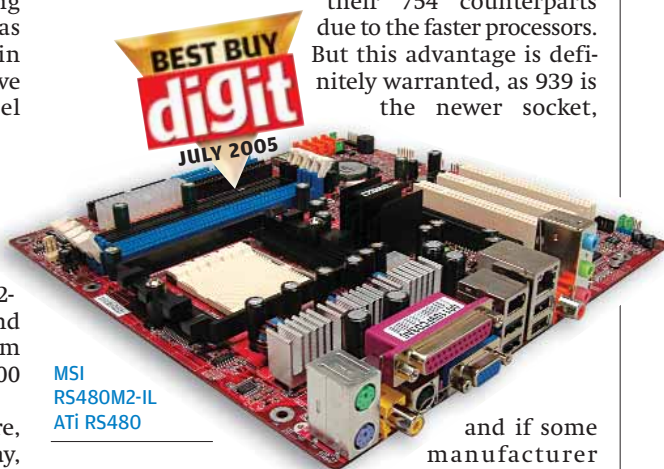
In second place was the TUL A480A7-VF. The loser here was the MSI RS480M. The flip-flops done by boards based on essentially the same chipset (most of these are based on the ATi RS480) really highlighted how important the process for chipset implementation is.

The story continued through 3DMark 2001 SE, where the RS480M2-IL zoomed ahead with a score of 5048. It was comfortably ahead of the TUL A480A7-VF, which scored a commendable 4611.

The worst performer here was the MSI RS480M with a score of 1027. This board really was a surprise, as MSI generally turns out very good motherboards.

We now come to our first overall system test, PCMark 2004.

Here, it needs to be clarified that the scores depend a fair bit on the processors used, and the 939 boards gained an advantage over their 754 counterparts due to the faster processors. But this advantage is definitely warranted, as 939 is the newer socket,



MSI
RS480M2-IL
ATi RS480

and if some manufacturer can give you a 939 board for the price someone else is giving you a 754 for, then it must reflect in the performance. This is why we did not make further segregations on the basis of processor sockets.

